

By abstaining from all non-necessary spending, I was able to fully focus on what was truly important. It was during my first no-spend challenge when I realized that going out with friends wasn't as much about the food as it was about the people. My no-spend challenges forced me to reexamine what I assumed I needed to spend on and get creative in how I met my needs.

Independent of Lembke's research, I found one month to be the sweet spot for initiating doable habit changes in my life. There are some great stories out there of people doing no-spend or low-spend years, and they're fascinating to read, but I wasn't trying to stop shopping for the sake of shopping. And a decade later, I still believe if your goal is to improve your spending habits without opting out of the system altogether, you don't need a whole no-spend year to learn that. Abstaining from nonessential spending for a month will allow you the space to focus on what's most important and rewire those reward pleasure pathways.

A quote I like from habit expert James Clear is "focus doesn't require a permanent no, but it does require a present no." Setting a thirty-day time limit to your no-spend challenge means you're not giving a permanent no to pleasure spending. You can and will go back to a lot of it. But a present "no" takes away some of the decision fatigue your brain experiences on a daily basis and gives you space to think more holistically about your spending decisions. With so much of our modern desire having been manufactured for us, taking a pause to consider what you truly love is an act of rebellion.

In 2017 I wanted to share with others what no-spend challenges had done for me, so I wrote a book titled *The No-Spend Challenge Guide* and published it on Amazon. And I had never dreamed of the response that little book would get. In seven years, the book has sold over twenty thousand copies and garnered over one thousand five-star reviews. In a world where personal finance books tell you to just stop spending money, the no-spend challenge is a way to learn what to stop spending money on. And it's working, at least for our readers:

"I have now been doing no-spend challenges periodically since reading and have been able to save, not only for myself but for my family, so we can enjoy more experiences together."

"I am saving more. I am spending intentionally. I am seeing results. My savings account balance is higher, and my anxiety level is lower!"